Bayesian Inverse Problem

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Ingredients

- Inverse Problem (IP)
- Uncertainty Quantification (UQ)
- Probability Theory
- Bayesian Inverse Problem

1 Introduction

1.1 Inverse problem

References.

- Aster, Borchers, and Thurber, 2018 [pdf]
- Ito and Jin, 2015 [pdf]
- Kirsch, 2021 [pdf]
- **[W/IP]** Wikipedia/Inverse Problem.

Sketches.

1. **Definition. [W/IP]** "An *inverse problem* in science is the process of calculating from a set of observations the causal factors that produced them."
2. **Intuition.** "It is called an inverse problem because it starts with the effects and then calculates the causes.

   It is the inverse of a *forward problem*, which starts with the causes and then calculates the effects."
3. **Motivation.** "Inverse problems are some of the most important mathematical problems in science and mathematics because they tell us about parameters that we cannot directly observe."
4. **Application.** Inverse problems "have wide application in system identification, optics, radar, acoustics, communication theory, signal processing, medical imaging, computer vision, geophysics, oceanography, astronomy, remote sensing, natural language processing, machine learning, nondestructive testing, slope stability analysis and many other fields.

Communities.

- WIAS/Research Group 4: *Nonlinear Optimization & Inverse Problem*.

1.1.1 Forward problem vs. inverse problem

Physical Model. $\mathcal{G}(u) \to y$.

- $u \in X$ parameter vector/parameter function
- $\mathcal{G} : X \to Y$ forward response operator
- y results/observations
- Evaluation of $\mathcal{G}$ expensive

Forward Problem. Find the output y for given parameters u.
Find the *unknown data* $u \in X$ from *noisy observations*

$$y = \mathcal{G}(u) + \eta \text{ with } \eta \sim \mathcal{N}(0, \Gamma).$$

- $u \in X$ parameter vector/parameter function
- $\mathcal{G} : X \to Y$ forward response operator
- y result/observations
- Evaluation of $\mathcal{G}$ expensive.

Forward Problem. $\boxed{\text{Find the output } y \text{ for given parameters } u} \to$ **well-posed**.

Inverse Problem. $\boxed{\text{Find the parameters } u \text{ from (noisy) observations } y} \to$ **ill-posed**.

Example 1.1 (2D Inhomogeneous sideways heat equations)**.** *Consider the following 2D inhomogeneous sideways heat equation (SHE):*

$$\begin{cases} \partial_t u - \Delta u = f(t,x,y), & \text{in } [0,\infty) \times \mathbb{R}^2, \\ u(t,0,y) = \phi(t,y), & \text{in } [0,\infty) \times \mathbb{R}, \\ \partial_x u(t,0,y) = \psi(t,y) & \text{in } [0,\infty) \times \mathbb{R}, \end{cases} \tag{2D-iSHE}$$

where ϕ, ψ: temperature, flux data *given in the* accessible region $x = 0$, *f: heat source density.*
(i) ***Determination of temperature.*** *Denote the 2D Fourier transform of a function $f(t,y)$ by*

$$\hat{f}(\tau,\xi) = \mathcal{F}(f)(\tau,\xi) = \frac{1}{2\pi}\int_{\mathbb{R}^2} f(t,y)e^{-\mathrm{i}(\tau t + \xi y)}\mathrm{d}y\mathrm{d}t, \ \forall(\tau,\xi) \in \mathbb{R}^2. \tag{2D-Ft}$$

extend the domain of time t from $[0,\infty)$ to $\mathbb{R}$, then applying the 2D Fourier transform (2D-Ft) w.r.t. y, t to (2D-iSHE), obtain in the frequency space the following 2nd-order ODE:

$$\begin{cases} \partial_x^2 \hat{u} - (\mathrm{i}\tau + \xi^2)\hat{u}(\tau,x,\xi) = \hat{f}(\tau,x,\xi), & \text{in } \mathbb{R}^3, \\ \hat{u}(\tau,0,\xi) = \hat{\phi}(\tau,\xi), & \text{in } \mathbb{R}^2, \\ \partial_x \hat{u}(\tau,0,\xi) = \hat{\psi}(\tau,\xi), & \text{in } \mathbb{R}^2. \end{cases}$$

Solving this ODE yields

$$\hat{u}(\tau,x,\xi) = \hat{\phi}(\tau,\xi)\cosh(x\theta) + \hat{\psi}(\tau,\xi)\frac{\sinh(x\theta)}{\theta} - \int_0^x \frac{\sinh((x-\eta)\theta)}{\theta}\hat{f}(\tau,\eta,\xi)\mathrm{d}\eta, \ \forall(\tau,x,\xi) \in \mathbb{R}^3, \tag{$\hat{u}$}$$

where $\theta = \theta(\tau,\xi)$ is the principle value of $\sqrt{\mathrm{i}\tau + \xi^2}$ and is given by

$$\theta(\tau,\xi) = \sqrt{\frac{\sqrt{\tau^2+\xi^4}+\xi^2}{2}} + \mathrm{i}\,\mathrm{sign}(\tau)\sqrt{\frac{\sqrt{\tau^2+\xi^4}-\xi^2}{2}}, \ \forall(\tau,\xi) \in \mathbb{R}^2.$$

This representation of $\hat{u}$ also indicates the ill-posedness of (2D-iSHE). Indeed, for $i = 1,2$, consider u_i solves (2D-iSHE) with the data (f_i, ϕ_i, ψ_i), and then

$$\hat{u}_i(\tau,x,\xi) = \hat{\phi}_i(\tau,\xi)\cosh(x\theta) + \hat{\psi}_i(\tau,\xi)\frac{\sinh(x\theta)}{\theta} - \int_0^x \frac{\sinh((x-\eta)\theta)}{\theta}\hat{f}_i(\tau,\eta,\xi)\mathrm{d}\eta, \ \forall(\tau,x,\xi) \in \mathbb{R}^3, \ \text{for } i = 1,2.$$

Subtract these, term by term, to obtain:

$$(\hat{u}_1-\hat{u}_2)(\tau,x,\xi)=(\hat{\phi}_1-\hat{\phi}_2)(\tau,\xi)\cosh(x\theta)+(\hat{\psi}_1-\hat{\psi}_2)(\tau,\xi)\frac{\sinh(x\theta)}{\theta}-\int_0^x\frac{\sinh((x-\eta)\theta)}{\theta}(\hat{f}_1-\hat{f}_2)(\tau,\eta,\xi)\mathrm{d}\eta,\ \forall(\tau,x,\xi)\in\mathbb{R}^3.$$

The perturbations in the data, which are indicated by $(\hat{f}_1-\hat{f}_2,\hat{\phi}_1-\hat{\phi}_2,\hat{\psi}_1-\hat{\psi}_2)$*, are magnified by the hyperbolic function* cosh *and even a singular kernel* $\frac{\sinh(x\theta)}{\theta}$ *whose a singularity is the origin of the frequency space, i.e.,* $(\tau,\xi)=(0,0)$.

Remark 1.1 (Generalization: $x=0$ to $x=x_0\in\mathbb{R}$)**.** *Note that by using the 2D Fourier transform* (2D-Ft)*, the solution of* (2D-iSHE) *where the Cauchy data* (ϕ,ψ) *is posed at* $x=x_0\in\mathbb{R}$ *instead of* $x=0$*, can be represented as*

$$\hat{u}(\tau,x,\xi)=\hat{\phi}(\tau,\xi)\cosh((x-x_0)\theta)+\hat{\psi}(\tau,\xi)\frac{\sinh((x-x_0)\theta)}{\theta}-\int_{x_0}^x\frac{\sinh((x-\eta)\theta)}{\theta}\hat{f}(\tau,\eta,\xi)\mathrm{d}\eta,\ \forall(\tau,x,\xi)\in\mathbb{R}^3.$$

- ***Ill-posedness.*** *Both kernels* $\cosh(x\theta)$, $\frac{\sinh(x\theta)}{\theta}$ *are unbounded for arbitrarily* $x\neq0$ *when* $\|(\tau,\xi)\|_2^2=\tau^2+\xi^2\to\infty$*, and thus small errors in the data can blow up and ultimately destroy the solution.*
- ***Measured data.*** *The measured data, denoted by* $(f_\delta,\phi_\delta,\psi_\delta)$*, where* $\delta>0$ *is called an* error level *(see, e.g., Ito and Jin, 2015; Kirsch, 2021), is typically assumed to satisfy*

$$\max\{\|f_\delta-f\|_{L^2(\mathbb{R}^3)},\|\phi_\delta-\phi\|_{L^2(\mathbb{R}^2)},\|\psi_\delta-\psi\|_{L^2(\mathbb{R}^2)}\}\le\delta. \tag{noise}$$

(ii) ***Determination of the thermal flux.*** *Differentiate the RHS of* ($\hat{u}$) *w.r.t.* x*, with the help of Leibnitz integral rule for the integral term, to obtain the following representation of the thermal flux w.r.t.* x

$$\partial_x\hat{u}(\tau,x,\xi)=\theta\hat{\phi}(\tau,\xi)\sinh(x\theta)+\hat{\psi}(\tau,\xi)\cosh(x\theta)-\int_0^x\cosh((x-\eta)\theta)\hat{f}(\tau,\eta,\xi)\mathrm{d}\eta,\ \forall(\tau,x,\xi)\in\mathbb{R}^3.$$

Blow-up kernels: $\sinh(x\theta)$, $\cosh((x-\eta)\theta)\to$ *ill-posedness.*

(iii) ***Numerical implementation.*** *The Cauchy data* $(u,\partial_x u)|_{x=0}=(\phi,\psi)$ *and the source term* $f(t,x,y)$ *are given and sampled at an equidistant grid in the domain* $[L,R]^2$ *with* $n\times n$ *points (*n*: sampling frequency), and the discretizations of* (f,ϕ,ψ) *are denoted by* $(\mathbf{F},\Phi,\Psi)$*, to distinguish them and their continuous counterparts.*

Main tools: MATLAB *builtin-in function* `fft2`*, which is used to carry out the 2D fast Fourier transforms (abbr., 2D FFT) of the given data, and* `ifft2`*, which is used to obtain 2D inverse fast Fourier transforms (abbr., 2D IIFT).*

Denote $\bar{x}\in[0,1]$ *the point at which we choose to observe the solutions and the thermal fluxes. Use Gauss-Legendre quadrature of order* m *for numerical integrations, where* $m\in\mathbb{Z}_{>0}$ *is chosen by users, i.e.,*

$$\int_0^{\bar{x}}\widehat{f}_\delta(\tau,\eta,\xi)\frac{\sinh((\bar{x}-\eta))}{\theta}\mathrm{d}\eta\approx\sum_{k=1}^m w_{m,k}\widehat{f}_\delta(\tau,x_{m,k},\xi)\frac{\sinh((\bar{x}-x_{m,k})\theta)}{\theta},$$
$$\int_0^{\bar{x}}\widehat{f}_\delta(\tau,\eta,\xi)\cosh((\bar{x}-\eta)\theta)\mathrm{d}\eta\approx\sum_{k=1}^m w_{m,k}\widehat{f}_\delta(\tau,x_{m,k},\xi)\cosh((\bar{x}-x_{m,k})\theta),$$

where $x_{m,k}$ *and* $w_{m,k}$ *are the nodes and weights of the Gauss-Legendre quadrature of degree* m *for the interval* $[0,\bar{x}]$*, resp. To apply these numerical integration formulas, it is necessary to carry out the 2D FFT of* f_δ *at each Gauss-Legendre quadrature's node.*

Add random noises to the (discrete) exact input data $(\mathbf{F},\Phi,\Psi)$*, i.e.:*

$$\begin{cases}\mathbf{F}_\delta(\cdot,x_{m,k},\cdot)=\mathbf{F}(\cdot,x_{m,k},\cdot)+\delta\,\mathtt{randn}(\mathtt{size}(\mathbf{F}(\cdot,x_{m,k},\cdot))),\ \forall k=1,\dots,m,\\ \Phi_\delta=\Phi+\delta\,\mathtt{randn}(\mathtt{size}(\Phi)),\ \Psi_\delta=\Psi+\delta\,\mathtt{randn}(\mathtt{size}(\Psi)),\end{cases} \tag{noise data}$$

where `randn()` *is a* MATLAB *built-in function.*

Denote $\|\cdot\|_{\overline{\mathrm{F}}}$ *the "average" Frobenius norm, i.e.:*

$$\|A\|_{\overline{\mathrm{F}}}:=\frac{1}{\sqrt{mn}}\|A\|_{\mathrm{F}}=\frac{1}{\sqrt{mn}}\left(\sum_{i=1}^m\sum_{j=1}^n|A_{ij}|^2\right)^{\frac12},\ \forall A\in\mathrm{Mat}_{\mathbb{C}}(m\times n),$$

where $\|\cdot\|_{\mathrm{F}}$ *is the Frobenius norm, we can define the total noises of the 3D array* $\mathbf{F}_\delta$ *and the matrices* $(\Phi_\delta,\Psi_\delta)$ *as*

$$\mathrm{TN}(\mathbf{F},\mathbf{F}_\delta):=\frac{1}{n\sqrt{m}}\left(\sum_{k=1}^m\|(\mathbf{F}_\delta-\mathbf{F})(\cdot,x_{m,k},\cdot)\|_{\mathrm{F}}^2\right)^{\frac12},\ \mathrm{TN}(\Phi,\Phi_\delta):=\|\Phi_\delta-\Phi\|_{\overline{\mathrm{F}}},\ \mathrm{TN}(\Psi,\Psi_\delta):=\|\Psi_\delta-\Psi\|_{\overline{\mathrm{F}}},\ \forall\delta>0. \tag{total noise}$$

After doing this, we obtain the noisy data $(\mathbf{F}_\delta, \Phi_\delta, \Psi_\delta)$ *satisfying the condition* $\max\{\mathrm{TN}(\mathbf{F}, \mathbf{F}_\delta), \mathrm{TN}(\Phi, \Phi_\delta), \mathrm{TN}(\Psi, \Psi_\delta)\} \leq \delta$, *which can be interpreted as the discrete analogue of* (noise). *We also use the norm* $\|\cdot\|_{\overline{\mathrm{F}}}$ *to calculate root mean square and relative errors, e.g.,*

$$\mathrm{RMSE}(\mathbf{U}_{\mathcal{R}}^\delta) := \|\mathbf{U}_{\mathcal{R}}^\delta - \mathbf{U}_{\mathrm{exact}}\|_{\overline{\mathrm{F}}}, \ \mathrm{RE}(\mathbf{U}_{\mathcal{R}}^\delta) := \frac{\|\mathbf{U}_{\mathcal{R}}^\delta - \mathbf{U}_{\mathrm{exact}}\|_{\overline{\mathrm{F}}}}{\|\mathbf{U}_{\mathrm{exact}}\|_{\overline{\mathrm{F}}}},$$

where $\mathbf{U}_{\mathrm{exact}}$, $\mathbf{U}_{\mathcal{R}}^\delta$ *is the discrete version of the solution* u *of* (2D-iSHE) *and its regularized analogue* $u_{\mathcal{R}}^\delta$ *on the sampled grid.*

Algorithm 1 Numerical implementation of a regularization method proposed for (2D-iSHE).

1: **Inputs:** observed point $x_{\mathrm{obs}} \in \mathbb{R}$, Cauchy data $[\phi, \psi]$ at $x = 0$, source term f, boundaries L and R of the computational domain $\Omega_{L,R}$, sampling frequency n, order $m \in \mathbb{Z}_{>0}$ of Gauss-Legendre quadrature, (approximate) nodes $x_{k,m}$ and (approximate) weights $w_{k,m}$ of the Gauss-Legendre quadrature of degree m for the interval $[0, x_{\mathrm{obs}}]$, noisy level $\delta > 0$, exact solution u or the set of its values at the grid points;
2: Generate an equidistant grid in the computational domain $\Omega_{L,R}$; ▷ Treat the origin $(0, 0)$ carefully
3: Compute the discrete exact data $(\mathbf{F}, \Phi, \Psi)$;
4: Generate the discrete noisy data $(\mathbf{F}_\delta, \Phi_\delta, \Psi_\delta)$ by (noise data);
5: (Optional) Compute the triple of the averaged noises $(\mathrm{TN}(\mathbf{F}, \mathbf{F}_\delta), \mathrm{TN}(\Phi, \Phi_\delta), \mathrm{TN}(\Psi, \Psi_\delta))$ of the discrete noisy data generated in Step 4 by (total noise); ▷ This triple will slightly change in magnitude in each execution due to randomness.
6: Compute 2D FFT $(\widehat{\mathbf{F}_\delta}, \widehat{\Phi_\delta}, \widehat{\Psi_\delta})$ of the discrete noisy data in Step 4 by `fft2`;
7: Compute 2D FFT of the discrete versions $\widehat{\mathbf{U}_\delta}$ and $\widehat{\mathbf{U}_{\mathcal{R}}^\delta}$ of $(\hat{u})$ and the regularized one(s);
8: Carry out both the discrete versions $\mathbf{U}_\delta$ and $\mathbf{U}_{\mathcal{R}}^\delta$ of the non-regularized and regularized solutions u_δ and $u_{\mathcal{R}}^\delta$ by `ifft2`;
9: Compute the corresponding Root Mean Square Error $\mathrm{RMSE}(\mathbf{U}_{\mathcal{R}}^\delta)$ and Relative Error $\mathrm{RE}(\mathbf{U}_{\mathcal{R}}^\delta)$;
10: (Optional) 3D-Plot the discrete non-regularized solution $\mathbf{U}_\delta$ and regularized solution $\mathbf{U}_{\mathcal{R}}^\delta$ on the equidistant grid generated in Step 2;
11: **Output:** Triple of the averaged noises $(\mathrm{TN}(\mathbf{F}, \mathbf{F}_\delta), \mathrm{TN}(\Phi, \Phi_\delta), \mathrm{TN}(\Psi, \Psi_\delta))$ (optional), non-regularized discrete solution $\mathbf{U}_\delta$, regularized discrete solution $\mathbf{U}_{\mathcal{R}}^\delta$, errors $\mathrm{RMSE}(\mathbf{U}_{\mathcal{R}}^\delta)$, $\mathrm{RE}(\mathbf{U}_{\mathcal{R}}^\delta)$, 3D plots of non-regularized and regularized solutions.

1.1.2 Deterministic Optimization Problem

Find the unknown data $u \in X$ from noisy observations

$$y = \mathcal{G}(u) + \eta.$$

Deterministic optimization problem

$$\min_{u \in X} \frac{1}{2}\|y - \mathcal{G}(u)\|^2 + R(u).$$

- $\|y - \mathcal{G}(u)\|$ potential/data misfit
- R regularization term
- Large-scale, deterministic optimization problem
- No quantification of the uncertainty in the unknown u
- Proper choice of the regularization term R

1.1.3 Bayesian Inverse Problem

Find the unknown data $u \in X$ from noisy observations $y = \mathcal{G}(u) + \eta$.
Bayesian inverse problem

- u, η, y random variables/fields
- Prior μ_0, posterior μ^y
- Goal of computation: moments of system quantities under the posterior w.r.t. noisy data

Prior $\to$ Forward Model $G \to$ (Noisy) Data y.
Posterior $\to$ Forward Model $G \to$

- $\star \to$ (Noisy) Data $y \to$ Posterior
- $\star \to$ Quantity of Interest
- Quantification of uncertainty in u & system quantities
- Well-posedness of the inverse problem
- Incorporation of prior knowledge on the uncertain data u
- Need for efficient approximations of the posterior

1.2 Uncertainty quantification

References.

- **[W/U]** Wikipedia/Uncertainty.
- **[W/UQ]** Wikipedia/Uncertainty Quantification.

Sketches.

1. **Definitions.** **[W/U]** "*Uncertainty* refers to epistemic situations involving imperfect or unknown information."

   [W/UQ] "*Uncertainty quantification* (UQ) is the science of quantitative characterization and reduction of uncertainties in both computational and real world applications."

2. **Intuition.** Uncertainty quantification "tries to determine how likely certain outcomes are if some aspects of the system are not exactly known".

3. **Motivation.** "Many problems in the natural sciences and engineering are also rife with sources of uncertainty." E.g., (see, e.g., **[Schillings_Teckentrup2017]**, Slides 3–4) *environmental systems* (weather, climate, seismic, subsurface geophysics), *engineering systems* (automobiles, aircraft, bridges, structures), *biological systems* (health & medicine, pharmaceuticals, gene expression, cancer research), *physical systems* (nano-optics, quantum physics, radioactive decay), etc.

4. **Sources of uncertainty.** **[W/UQ]** "Uncertainty can enter mathematical models and experimental measurements in various contexts."

   Categorization of sources of uncertainty. Consider: parameter uncertainty, parametric variability, structural uncertainty/model inadequacy/model bias/model discrepancy, algorithmic uncertainty/numerical uncertainty/discrete uncertainty, experimental uncertainty/observation error, interpolation uncertainty.

   Classification of uncertainty.

   - *Aleatoric uncertainty/statistical uncertainty* is representative of unknowns that differ each time we run the same experiment. E.g., MATLAB built-in function `rand()`.

     "The quantification for the aleatoric uncertainties can be relatively straightforward, where traditional (frequentist) probability is the most basic form."
   - *Epistemic uncertainty/systematic uncertainty* is due to things one could in principle know but do not in practice, which may be because a measurement is not accurate, because the model neglects certain effects, or because particular data has been deliberately hidden. E.g., $g = 9.8\text{m/s}^2$ ignores the effects of air resistance.

     "To evaluate epistemic uncertainties, the efforts are made to understand the (lack of) knowledge of the system, process or mechanism."

   "Uncertainty quantification intends to explicitly express both types of uncertainty separately."

   Mathematical perspective of aleatoric & epistemic uncertainty. "In mathematics, uncertainty is often characterized in terms of a probability distribution. From that perspective, epistemic uncertainty means not being certain what the relevant probability distribution is, and aleatoric uncertainty means not being certain what a random sample drawn from a probability distribution will be."

5. **Quantification & minimization of uncertainties.**

   - Uncertainty quantification in numerical simulations
   - Minimization of uncertainties in design & control problems

- Identification of uncertain parameters from noisy observations

Related research fields. Numerical analysis, methods for optimal control/optimization problems, approximation theory, stochastic, statistics, algorithms & data structures.

Communities.

- WIAS/Research Group 5: *Interacting Random Systems*.
- WIAS/Research Group 6: *Stochastic Algorithms & Nonparametric Statistics*.

1.3 Probability Theory

1.4 Bayesian Inverse Problems

References.

- [**Schillings_Teckentrup2017**] Schillings, Claudia & Teckentrup, Aretha, 2017. *Mathematical Foundations of Bayesian Inverse Problems: Well-posedness & Statistical Estimates in Bayesian Inverse Problems.* [pdf]

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